Jyotiraditya Scindia's convoy arrives at Kadwaya village in Ashoknagar district just as the summer sun begins to set over the harvested wheat fields, and comes to a halt at the *chaupal*. This is the last meeting of the day for the BJP candidate from Guna Lok Sabha constituency, having started his campaign that morning from Chanderi, the town renowned for its fabric. A group of trumpeters and drummers herald Scindia's arrival as he ascends a small dais. Addressing the gathered crowd moments later, he invokes his royal family's longstanding ties with the region—where his grandmother Vijaya Raje and father Madhavrao served as MPs. There's no mistaking the emotional appeal—evident even in wife Priyadarshini and son Mahanaaryaman's campaigning in the constituency.

As a Congress candidate in 2019, the four-time Lok Sabha MP had lost—the first time for his family in Guna—to the BJP's K.P. Singh Yadav. The next year, a few days before India went into a Covid lockdown, Scindia switched to the saffron side and later brought down the 15-month-old Congress government headed by Kamal Nath. That year, he was elected to the Rajya Sabha before being appointed a Union minister. A victory here will erase the humiliation of the past, though he denies it ever made a difference.

How do things look for Scindia in Guna? Across the country, BJP candidates have often highlighted the achievements of the Modi government while seeking votes from the constituents. It is a well-calculated strategy, leveraging the Modi factor to overshadow the individual candidate or their community. Not in Guna. Out here, Scindia references both his accomplishments as a minister and those of the Modi government during public addresses. "I recall the times when there were no roads in this region," he declares at a *nukkad* meeting in Kadwaya. "I facilitated roads as well as electricity connections." He also cites his achievements in his current tenure as the minister for civil aviation and steel, such as establishing Kendriya Vidyalayas and airports. Then, he brings in the Modi government's achievements, including Ayushman cards, free ration for 800 million people and the lunar mission. He saves the blast for the last, running down his political opponents at the end of the address. "Had I not pulled down the Congress government in 2020, the funds allocated for programmes like Kisan Samman Nidhi and Ladli Behna would have been pocketed by Congress leaders," he thunders.



THE BID TO WIN
Jyotiraditya Scindia at an election campaign in Guna, Apr. 24



2019

WINNER
K.P. Singh Yadav (BJP)
52% vote share

RUNNER-UP
Jyotiraditya Scindia (Congress)
41.5% vote share

2014

WINNER
Jyotiraditya Scindia (Congress)
52.9% vote share

RUNNER-UP
Jaibhan Singh Pawaiya (BJP)
40.6% vote share

The Congress strategy in Guna borrows from the BJP playbook when Scindia and his late father Madhavrao contested as Congress candidates—framing the battle along community lines. The Yadavs constitute the largest caste group in the region, and the Congress has nominated Rao Yadvendra Singh Yadav, son of veteran BJP leader Rao Deshraj Singh Yadav. In 2019, the BJP had K.P. Singh Yadav as its candidate, who has now been dropped. How does the BJP plan to counter the consolidation of the Yadav vote? By highlighting their new Yadav chief minister, Mohan Yadav. They also have Mungaoli MLA Brajendra Yadav and Kolaras MLA Mahendra Yadav, to showcase among its prominent Yadav leaders. On April 26, Union home minister Amit Shah while addressing a rally for Scindia at Ashoknagar said, "K.P. Yadav has served the people of this area very well. The BJP will do everything that can be done to promote him." The message was meant to assuage the Yadav community whose member had been overlooked for the ticket in favour of Scindia.

Earlier, the speculation had been that Scindia preferred contesting from Gwalior rather than Guna, given his noticeable work there. However, the Gwalior BJP ticket went to former